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Philosophy of Politics:
Nazism: philosophical and ideological
sources

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Nazism: Philosophical and Ideological Sources

- Historical and intellectual origins of National Socialism
- Race, nation and *Volksgemeinschaft*
- Antisemitism and racial hierarchy
- Social Darwinism, geopolitics and leadership
- Central question: *How did Nazism transform existing intellectual currents into a racial and existential conception of politics?*

What Is National Socialism?

- National Socialism emerged as a radical political movement in post–World War I Germany
- It combined extreme nationalism, racial antisemitism and anti-Marxism
- It rejected liberal-democratic pluralism and political equality
- Political community was defined primarily through racial categories
- The *Volk* rather than the autonomous individual became the fundamental political unit

Nazism Had No Single Philosophical Source

- Nazism did not emerge from one philosopher or coherent philosophical system
- It appropriated ideas from multiple nineteenth and early twentieth-century currents
- Existing concepts were selectively interpreted and radicalized
- Political propaganda often mattered more than philosophical consistency
- **Intellectual genealogy is not the same as intellectual responsibility**

Sources of Nazi Ideology

- *Völkisch* nationalism
- Racial theories and antisemitism
- Social Darwinist interpretations of human conflict
- Imperialism and geopolitical thinking
- Anti-liberal and anti-Marxist political currents

The German National Question

- German political unification occurred in 1871
- National identity had developed before political unification
- Language, culture and historical memory became important markers of belonging
- Competing definitions of Germanness persisted after unification
- Nazism later racialized the question: *Who counts as German?*

From Nation to *Volk*

- *Volk* can mean people or nation
- In *völkisch* thought it acquired ethnic and cultural meanings
- Community was imagined through ancestry, culture and historical belonging
- Political membership could therefore be conceived as inherited rather than chosen
- Nazism radicalized this tradition through racial categorization

Völkisch Nationalism

- Developed through diverse movements rather than one unified doctrine
- Romanticized an organic national community
- Frequently criticized cosmopolitanism and modern urban society
- Some currents incorporated racial antisemitism
- Nazism absorbed and transformed elements of this intellectual environment

Organic Political Community

- Society is understood as an organism rather than an association of autonomous individuals
- Individuals derive meaning from membership in the larger community
- Difference can be interpreted as functional or hierarchical
- Political unity takes priority over individual autonomy
- Nazism gives this organic metaphor a specifically racial foundation

Volksgemeinschaft

- Literally: “people's community” or “national community”
- Promised unity beyond conventional class divisions
- Membership depended on racial inclusion
- Community therefore simultaneously meant belonging and exclusion
- *Who belongs becomes the foundational political question*

Liberal Citizenship vs. Racial Membership

- Liberal citizenship is fundamentally juridical and political
- Citizens possess rights as individuals
- Nazi ideology interprets membership through racial ancestry
- Legal status becomes connected to biological classification
- Political equality is consequently rejected at the conceptual level

Race Before Nazism

- Nineteenth-century Europe witnessed attempts to classify humanity into supposed biological races
- Such classifications often established hierarchies among populations
- Imperialism provided political contexts for racial doctrines
- Antisemitism increasingly adopted racial as well as religious forms
- Nazism inherited and radicalized these currents

From Religious to Racial Antisemitism

- Anti-Jewish prejudice had a long European history
- Traditional hostility was frequently religious
- Modern antisemitism increasingly portrayed Jewish identity as inherited and racial
- Conversion therefore could no longer remove the supposed difference
- Nazism made racial antisemitism central to its worldview

Antisemitism as a Worldview

- Nazi antisemitism went beyond ordinary prejudice against a minority
- Jews were portrayed as a racial and existential enemy
- Diverse social phenomena were attributed to supposed Jewish influence
- Capitalism and communism could simultaneously be incorporated into conspiratorial narratives
- Antisemitism provided an imagined explanation for social complexity

Houston Stewart Chamberlain

- Chamberlain's *Foundations of the Nineteenth Century* appeared in 1899
- It presented European history through racial categories
- “Germanic” peoples were assigned a privileged historical role
- Jews were constructed as a racial counterforce
- His writings contributed to the racial-nationalist intellectual environment later exploited by Nazism

Arthur de Gobineau

- Gobineau developed an influential nineteenth-century theory of racial inequality
- Historical development was interpreted through racial difference and mixture
- His ideas circulated widely beyond France
- Later racial theorists adapted his arguments for different political purposes
- Nazism inherited racial thinking but did not simply reproduce Gobineau's theory

Social Darwinism

- Darwin's biological theory concerned evolution through natural selection
- Other thinkers extended evolutionary language into social and political life
- Competition among individuals, classes, nations or “races” was presented as natural
- Inequality could consequently be interpreted as biologically grounded
- These extensions should be distinguished from Darwin's biological theory itself

Politics as Biological Struggle

- Nazi ideology interprets history through racial competition
- Conflict is treated as permanent rather than accidental
- Survival requires strength and expansion
- Political compromise can appear as weakness
- Politics becomes connected to a supposed struggle for biological existence

Nature as Political Justification

- Nazi texts repeatedly invoke “nature”
- Hierarchy is presented as natural
- Racial difference is presented as natural
- Struggle is presented as natural
- Political arrangements are therefore portrayed as consequences of biological necessity rather than choices

The Naturalistic Problem

- Descriptions of nature do not automatically generate political obligations
- Competition in nature does not logically establish how societies ought to be organized
- Biological categories do not themselves establish political rights
- Nazi ideology collapses descriptive and normative claims
- *When does an alleged fact about nature become a justification for political domination?*

Nietzsche and Nazism: A Necessary Distinction

- Friedrich Nietzsche criticized egalitarian morality and aspects of modern mass society
- Nazi intellectuals selectively appropriated parts of his vocabulary and reputation
- Nietzsche himself was not a National Socialist
- His writings contain significant tensions with later Nazi ideology, including its nationalism and antisemitism
- Nazi appropriation should therefore be distinguished from Nietzsche's own philosophy

Intellectual Appropriation

- Political ideologies rarely inherit philosophical texts unchanged
- Concepts can be removed from their original context
- Ambiguous language can acquire new political meanings
- Thinkers can be incorporated into ideological traditions after their deaths
- Nazism provides an important example of *selective intellectual appropriation*

World War I

- Germany experienced mass mobilization and industrialized warfare
- Military defeat in 1918 produced profound political disruption
- The German Empire collapsed
- Revolutionary movements emerged
- Wartime experiences shaped later political cultures of violence, sacrifice and national struggle

The “Stab-in-the-Back” Myth

- Germany's military defeat generated competing political explanations
- Nationalists promoted the false claim that Germany had been betrayed internally
- Jews, socialists and democratic politicians were among those targeted
- The myth delegitimized the new republican order
- Nazism incorporated it into a broader narrative of national betrayal

The Weimar Republic

- Established after the collapse of the German Empire
- Parliamentary and constitutional democracy
- Faced political violence from revolutionary and counterrevolutionary forces
- Experienced severe economic and political crises
- Nazism defined itself against the republic's pluralist political order

Anti-Liberalism

- Liberalism begins from individuals possessing rights
- Nazism begins from a racially defined political community
- Liberalism protects political and social pluralism
- Nazism interprets pluralism as fragmentation
- Individual rights therefore become subordinate to racial-national objectives

Anti-Marxism

- Marxism interprets history primarily through class relations
- Nazism rejects international proletarian solidarity
- Class conflict is portrayed as destructive of national unity
- Workers are to be incorporated into the racial-national community
- *Race replaces class as the primary category of historical conflict*

“National Socialism”

- Nazi “socialism” did not mean Marxist social ownership or abolition of class through proletarian revolution
- The movement rejected Marxist class struggle
- Economic groups were expected to serve national objectives
- Private property continued under the Nazi regime, subject to extensive political direction
- National unity was prioritized over class solidarity

Geopolitics and *Lebensraum*

- Nazi ideology linked racial politics with territorial expansion
- *Lebensraum* means “living space”
- Territory was treated as necessary for the survival and expansion of the racial community
- Eastern Europe became central to Nazi expansionist ambitions
- Foreign policy was therefore connected directly to racial ideology

Lebensraum as Racial Politics

- Territory was not conceived simply as strategic space
- Expansion involved demographic transformation
- Existing populations were classified through racial hierarchies
- Conquest and racial reordering became interconnected
- The distinction between domestic racial policy and foreign policy consequently weakened

Hitler's *Mein Kampf*

- Written during the 1920s and published in 1925–1926
- Combines autobiography, propaganda and ideological argument
- Race and antisemitism are central themes
- Propaganda, leadership and political organization receive extensive attention
- The text provides evidence for Hitler's ideological worldview rather than a systematic philosophy

Hitler's Racial Worldview

- Humanity is divided into supposedly unequal racial groups
- History is interpreted as racial struggle
- Racial mixture is presented as degeneration
- Political institutions should preserve the racial community
- These pseudoscientific premises structure Hitler's conception of politics

Propaganda in *Mein Kampf*

- Hitler treats propaganda as an instrument of mass politics
- Propaganda should simplify complex political questions
- Emotional mobilization is prioritized over nuanced argument
- Messages should be repeatedly communicated to broad audiences
- Politics becomes partly a struggle over the interpretation of reality

Masses and Political Psychology

- Nazi political theory is skeptical of autonomous mass political judgment
- Mass publics are portrayed as emotionally responsive
- Political communication should therefore simplify choices
- Symbols, repetition and collective identity become politically important
- This conception supports a hierarchical relationship between leader and followers

The Leadership Principle

- *Führerprinzip* means the principle of leadership
- Authority flows hierarchically from leaders to subordinates
- Leadership is associated with personal responsibility and command
- Parliamentary bargaining is rejected as politically weak
- The principle would later structure important parts of the Nazi political order

Leader and *Volk*

- The leader is presented as expressing the political will of the racial community
- Representation is not understood primarily through competitive elections
- Leader and people are rhetorically portrayed as politically unified
- Opposition can therefore be characterized as opposition to the community itself
- *Representation becomes identification rather than authorization*

Carl Schmitt and the Nazi Context

- Schmitt developed major parts of his political theory before the Nazi seizure of power
- He joined the Nazi Party in 1933 and publicly supported aspects of the new regime
- His concepts include sovereignty, political unity and the friend–enemy distinction
- Schmitt's political theory is not reducible to Nazi racial doctrine
- His relationship to Nazism therefore requires both conceptual and historical distinction

The Friend–Enemy Distinction

- For Schmitt, the specifically political distinction is friend and enemy
- The political enemy is a public rather than merely personal enemy
- Political conflict can reach an existential intensity
- The possibility of conflict defines the autonomy of the political
- This framework helps us analyze *existential politics* without equating Schmitt's concept directly with Nazi racial ideology

From Political Enemy to Racial Enemy

- Schmitt conceptualizes political conflict through collective friend and enemy
- Nazi ideology defines the community through race
- The enemy can consequently be portrayed as biologically threatening
- Political disagreement becomes an existential struggle over collective survival
- *Once enemies are racialized, political conflict becomes difficult to limit*

The Ideological Architecture of Nazism

- **Political subject:** racial *Volk*
- **Fundamental conflict:** existential racial struggle
- **Political principle:** unity and hierarchy
- **Authority:** leadership rather than pluralist competition
- **Objective:** preservation, expansion and domination of the racial community

The Nazi Question

- *Völkisch nationalism: Who belongs to the political community?*
- *Racial ideology: Can political membership be biologically defined?*
- *Hitler: How can masses be mobilized around a racial worldview?*
- *Schmitt: What happens when politics is understood through existential conflict?*
- *Fundamental question: What happens to politics when citizenship, rights and disagreement are replaced by racial belonging and existential categories of friend and enemy?*